

Army and took command of a Virginia brigade. At the First Battle of Bull Run in July 1861, he saw little action but recommended an immediate thrust toward Washington in the aftermath, before the enemy could regroup. Here was a glimpse of the future corps commander: an operational-level leader with the vision and foresight to predict second and third-order effects of tactical decisions. Promoted to major general in October, he took command of a division, which saw action during the 1862 Peninsula Campaign.

Winning Lee's trust

General Lee realized what an excellent lieutenant he possessed in "Old Pete" by the time of the Second Bull Run Campaign, where Longstreet commanded half the Army of Northern Virginia. But Longstreet's delays in launching an attack against an unprepared General John Pope and the Federal Army of Virginia frustrated Lee, who ordered him forward three times on August 29.

When Longstreet finally attacked, at 6:30p.m., the best chance to destroy Pope had slipped away. He redeemed himself the next day by throwing every brigade at his disposal against Pope's left flank. The massive assault overwhelmed Pope and earned Longstreet a reputation for slow but relentless attacks that started late but ended up in decisive victory. Such a characterization may have surprised Longstreet, who felt most at home repulsing ill-conceived enemy attacks. In September 1862, he did just that at Antietam, utilizing the terrain to protect his troops. Yet, at the end of the day, he felt that more time would have allowed the construction of fieldworks and artillery "killing zones." At Fredericksburg in December, he set up overlapping fields of fire for his artillery and infantry and prepared safe positions behind which his men easily repelled Union assaults.

After Fredericksburg, Longstreet consistently urged Lee to seek an "offensive-defensive" battle, in which the Confederates took the war to the enemy operationally, but then assumed a tactically defensive role on ground of their choosing. Longstreet reasoned that